

Fig. 9.2: The Bhoria stupa in the Girnar forest, the massive cut created by nineteenth-century excavations still visible

Structural relics in the landscape of Junagadh which have an early association with Buddhism reinforce the idea. One such is the Bhoria stupa, also called the Lakha Medi stupa. Located in a state-protected forest known as the Girnar Reserve Sanctuary near the present-day Bhordevi temple complex, this is the most impressive early Buddhist structural relic of the area. Built on a rocky knoll some 7 km to the east of Junagadh city, it stands in a delightfully secluded valley which provides a magnificent view of both the rugged Girnar and the Datar hill, the highest mountain after Girnar. Excavated by J.M. Campbell in 1889, with the massive cutting left behind by him still clearly visible, the entire ground around it is strewn with bricks and brick fragments, as also many small mounds. The main stupa is made of solid brick in herringbone bond.[14] Inside, a stone coffer was found with a stone pot. Inside this pot were relic boxes of copper, silver, and gold, with semiprecious and precious stones—such as an aquamarine bead, a ruby, a